

WE WANT A PEACE WHICH WILL BE JUST

THE TREATY OF VERSAILLES (1919)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

International law

BEFORE

1907 The Triple Entente sets Britain, France, and Russia in an alliance to confront the Central Powers—Germany and Austria-Hungary.

1918 Germany and Austria-Hungary agree to an armistice. Fighting ends with possibly 9 million servicemen killed and 11 million civilians dead.

1918 Revolutions convulse Germany after it surrenders.

AFTER

1923 The fledgling Weimar Republic, the government of Germany, falters under the strain of hyperinflation.

1929–1933 During the Great Depression, unemployment in Germany soars to 6 million.

1933 Adolf Hitler is confirmed as German Chancellor; Nazi one-party rule soon follows.

The Treaty of Versailles was signed on June 28, 1919, between the victorious Allied powers of World War I and the defeated German Empire. Over the following 14 months, four more treaties were concluded with Austria, Bulgaria, Hungary, and Turkey. Further treaties were signed with Turkey in 1923 and Germany in 1925.

The treaties remade the map of Europe. The Austro-Hungarian and Ottoman Empires were dismantled; the former Russian Empire, now convulsed by civil war, was dramatically reduced.

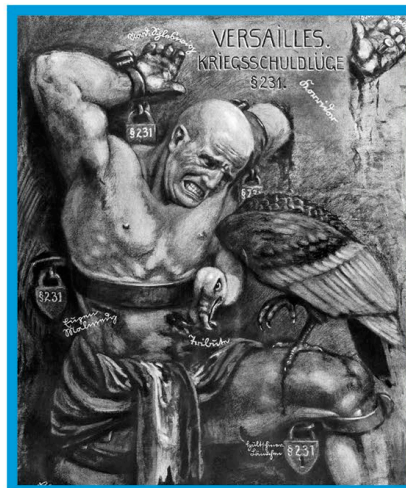
Eight new nation-states were also created: Czechoslovakia, Estonia, Finland, Hungary, Latvia, Lithuania, Poland, and Yugoslavia.

The 1919 Treaty had been drafted at the Versailles Peace Conference, attended by 27 nations but led by Britain, France, Italy, and the US. The prime impetus for the conference had come from US president Woodrow Wilson. His ideal was a democratic, open, and equal league of nations (see box, opposite) based on “self-determination,” forging a new peaceful and prosperous world.

Wilson’s vision for Europe was undermined by the impossibility of creating coherent nation-states out of multiethnic peoples and by other Allies’ political imperatives.

Punishing Germany

British prime minister David Lloyd George and French premier Georges Clemenceau were set on a “war guilt clause.” The logic was simple: since Germany was responsible for



Germany is shackled, in this 1932 protest poster by Heinz Wever, by the weight of reparations as a result of the “war guilt” ascribed to the country in Article 231 of the Treaty of Versailles.